

BRAIN

Some research suggests that the more emotional parts of your brain become dominant during pregnancy. This may occur to begin the bonding process with your baby—making you more emotionally attuned to your baby's needs.

LIVER

Your baby's waste passes through your system, which means that your liver has to work harder than usual to detoxify your own body. To accommodate the extra workload, it will often increase in size.

BREASTS

Your breasts prepare to produce milk from as early as seven weeks pregnant and in the following weeks you will notice them begin to grow. You might also notice that your areolae are darker, and that little bumps have appeared around your nipples; these are known as Montgomery's tubercles and these will secrete fluid to help entice your baby to your nipple. Toward the end of your pregnancy, your body will create a highly sophisticated milk manufacturing and delivery system. Lobules within the breast get bigger and, even before you've had your baby, begin to make colostrum—a highly nutritious liquid that your baby drinks before your milk “comes in.” Also, the delivery mechanism within your breast increases to make sure there are plenty of channels supplying milk to your nipples.

HEART

Your heart pumps harder throughout your pregnancy, increasing from around 65 beats per minute at the beginning of pregnancy to around 75 beats per minute by the time you are at full term. This is so that your body can meet your baby's increasing demands for nutrients and oxygen as she grows.

SPINE

As your pregnancy progresses, your center of gravity changes. As your belly grows forward, your center of gravity shifts forward, which means you have to “lean back” on your spine to correct your balance and stay upright. Your spine allows you to do this, but the unnatural posture may give you a backache.

PELVIS

This is key to your baby's safety during pregnancy and at birth. At the beginning, the pelvic bones provide protection for your developing uterus. Then, during birth, your pelvis expands and contracts to push your baby through into the birth canal, even forcing her to turn during her descent.

HIPS

Your body produces increasing amounts of the hormone relaxin, which loosens your ligaments. This can cause a few aches and pains during your pregnancy, but it allows your bones to move outward enough to enable your baby to pass through your pelvis during birth. Your hips may also become more rounded as your body stores extra fat during pregnancy. This provides fuel for making milk.

VEINS AND ARTERIES

Your blood volume will increase by up to 45 percent during your pregnancy and it gets better at clotting in preparation for when you give birth to your baby and when the placenta comes away from your uterus—the blood needs to clot quickly to minimize blood loss. Pregnancy hormones cause your blood vessels to dilate—that is, they open up to allow more blood to pass through them.